Program Revision: Advanced Certificate in Digital Humanities
Prepared by: DH Certificate Review Task Force (Filipa Calado, John Decker)
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Overview

We are proposing revision to the Advanced Certificate in Digital Humanities (DH Cert). The certificate was approved in November 2014. As the School of Information's goal is to review programs on a six-year rotation, this program is well past its time for review. A small task force, including Anthony Cocciolo, Irene Lapatovska, Claudia Berger, and Quinn Lai, assembled in the Fall of 2024 to review relevant documentation (e.g., relevant publications about Digital Humanities, internal surveys, job advertisements, student outcomes, etc.). The revision committee found two key issues that require revision of the certificate:

a) The program-level student learning outcomes (PLOs) are dated and do not reflect the more advanced level of work that is expected of students coming out of the final course INFO 659 Advanced Projects in Digital Humanities.
b) The curriculum table in the catalog has been corrupted over time. For example, the first set of courses in the elective list does not have a "bucket" (or topic) holding them together like the other sets of courses. Further, the elective courses and the "buckets" need reconfiguring in light of the research the task force conducted.

In response to December 2024 feedback from the School of Information Curriculum Committee, a new taskforce, including Filipa Calado and John Decker, formed in Fall of 2025 to address the relationship between elective courses and program-level learning outcomes. The 2025 committee affirms the findings of the 2024 committee, and additionally affirms that further revision is required.

Students

The DH Cert is a small program with, on average, 3-4 students completing it each year. All students who have completed it are either enrolled in the MS Library & Information Science program or MS in Museums and Digital Culture program, with none opting to do the certificate as a standalone program. It would be beneficial to attract MS Data Analytics and Visualization students to the program–athough existing text in the catalog and on the web that mentions academic libraries and cultural institutions may steer them away.

While DH practitioners have often found positions as DH Librarians or DH Specialists in the past, this is changing both inside and outside the library. Inside the library, the combination of technical, research, and communication skills required for DH can be leveraged for more increasingly technical positions—positions which may attract both LIS and DAV students. Digitally-oriented roles in libraries, for example, in "digital stewardship" (i.e. metadata, copyright, digital content management), "DH methods and tools" (text analysis, GIS/mapping), and "software development" (web and database development) are currently expanding to include job titles like Software

Engineer, AI & Machine Learning Developer, and Humanities Data Scientist (Walsh et al.; *code4lib jobs*).

These newer roles demand a higher level of technical proficiency combined with traditional cultural heritage expertise. For example, a recent job posting for “Data Scientist – Digital Humanities & Archives” at Penn State University seeks a candidate that can offer “innovative approaches to emphasize community engagement and ethical stewardship in archival collection work.” The listed qualifications combine technical skills (“proficiency in Python,” “artificial intelligence”) within a traditionally humanistic focus on ethics and cultural heritage knowledge (“Data Scientist – Digital Humanities & Archives”). Another library job, “Digital Scholarship Specialist” from the University of Michigan, seeks a candidate “to enhance learning, teaching, and scholarship through application of technologies and knowledge of the latest digital research methods.” This position specifies experience in “project management” and “teaching and consulting” across “levels of expertise and ability… with technology” (“Digital Scholarship Specialist”). Finally, a more directly technical job, “Digital Humanities Specialist - Arts and Sciences, IT” at Washington University, seeks an individual who can build “custom programs and shared open-source software to meet the evolving needs of various research projects…. Maintain server environments”, as well as and “provide mentorship… for graduate and undergraduate students” and “meet with faculty” to translate “academic goals… into technical plans for software and data management” (Digital Humanities Specialist - Arts and Sciences, IT”). These positions expand the traditional qualifications of research and communication to include a technical skillset that can grapple with increasing needs in digital research and preservation.

Outside the library, the rise of automated digital research tools is rapidly raising the demand for humanistic skills in technical work (Ma). DH’s emphasis on critical approaches to technology, especially for “communication, critical thinking, creativity, innovation, [and] ethical reasoning,” offers graduates with both a digital skillset and training in DH an advantage in applying to positions like project managers, data analysts, and mapping specialists, among others (Diedrich; Schuessler; *University of Sheffield Careers*). Project manager job descriptions, for example, tend to seek high-level judgement and interpretive skills alongside technical coordination work. These job ads highlight responsibilities such as “set and manage stakeholder expectations”, “perform regular assessment of project execution,” alongside requirements for “critical thinking and problem-solving skills” (*Forbes*). Similarly, many current Data Analyst postings mention not only coding and data visualization but also critical thinking and research skills to deeply analyze problems and to “interpret and communicate” information to varied audiences (*Indeed*). Together, these examples show that employers increasingly pair technical proficiency with analytical and interpretive capacities, reinforcing the value of DH’s critically informed skill set particularly for students in DAV.

Academic Year	LIS	MDC	DAV	Stand-alone	Total
2023-2024	3	0	0	0	3
2022-2023	3	1	0	0	4
2021-2022	3	1	0	0	4
2020-2021	2	1	0	0	3
2019-2020	3	0	0	0	3

2018-2019	2	0	0	0	2
2017-2018	4	0	0	0	4

Faculty

The School of Information has full-time faculty as well as part-time faculty who engage in the area of DH:

FT Faculty
Dr. Filipa Calado
Dr. John Decker
Dr. Craig Fahner (joining in fall 2026)
Dr. Nancy Smith

PT Faculty
Claudia Berger (Alum of DH certificate)
Benjamin Zweig

Other
Dr. Chris Alen Sula (Former FT faculty and now Assoc. Provost)

Program-Level Learning Outcomes

The revised certificate defines Digital Humanities as an interdisciplinary field that combines critical humanistic inquiry with computation technologies. The program therefore balances two complementary areas of training: (1) theoretical, ethical, and methodological approaches to the study of culture, information, and technology; and (2) technical means used to create, analyze, preserve, visualize, and communicate digital scholarship and cultural heritage materials. The revised curriculum reflects this dual emphasis through the organization of electives into “Theory and Methods” and “Technologies” buckets, culminating in advanced project-based work in INFO 659.

The re-organization of electives into the “Theory and Methods” and “Technologies” buckets reflects necessary components of DH training based in current Pratt SI courses: in an area of knowledge expertise representing theoretical interests in DH scholarship (accessibility, speculative design); and in technical approaches based on skills (such as programming, data design and digital preservation). This revision does not alter the number of credits required for the certificate.

The re-organization of the certificate includes elective courses that leverage the expertises of programs in the School of Information, including GIS/mapping, UXD, and Digital Preservation (LIS). GIS/mapping has become a major focus in DH research, and knowledge of mapping tools is increasingly needed for high-level DH projects. Meanwhile, UX design principles have become a vital means of facilitating the usability of DH projects and digital preservation equips students to

think long-term about project longevity, sustainability, and “sunsetting” projects, which is now standard in DH project planning.

The SLOs for the program are not published in the graduate catalog, and we aim to have them published once revised. The revised program-level learning outcomes are:

By the end of this advanced certificate program, students will be able to:

Current Learning Outcome	**Revised Learning Outcome**
develop critical awareness of current topics in digital humanities, including theory, methods, and applications;	apply theoretical and critical approaches from digital humanities to analyze cultural and information-based materials. [happens in INFO-657]
build skills in content management; digitization; preservation; data collections, analysis, and visualization; and technology as applied to academic settings and cultural heritage institutions;	select and use appropriate technological approaches to collect, manage, analyze, visualize, preserve, and communicate humanities and cultural heritage data. [happens in electives]
be prepared to support faculty/institutional research, teaching, and professional development in the area of digital humanities; and	work across technological contexts to collaborate on and evaluate digital humanities projects. [happens in INFO 659]
be able to act as thought leaders in the areas of digital scholarship and public engagement at academic libraries and cultural heritage institutions	

Curriculum Table Update version 3

The proposed revision to the curriculum preserves the required courses (INFO 657, INFO 659) from version 1. Though the revision notes that INFO 659, which offers “Mastery” of the SLOs, should be taken in the last semester in the certificate. The work completed in INFO 659 shows mastery of the PLOs, with the other courses required in the certificate there to help develop skills and knowledge that will be used in that course.

The revision also does make notable changes to the electives. First, the “Technologies” bucket was created and populated with courses that reflect training in technical tools. Technical skill development, particularly in one area of expertise like data analysis or web development, is essential for engaging in advanced digital humanities work. This revision adds mapping (**INFO 609**)

to the technical skills already on offer, including data analysis (**INFO 640**), databases (**INFO 639**), web development (**INFO 638**), building web apps (**INFO 637**), digital curation and preservation (**INFO 655**), and Python programming (**INFO 664**). It also includes statistics (**INFO 610**) to help build greater analytical capabilities.

A second bucket, “Theory and Methods” was created to reflect that contemporary DH practice draws from various knowledge areas across disciplinary fields and focus areas. Introducing students to research design (**INFO 630**) is an important means of providing future DH researchers with context and knowledge needed to carry out complex studies. Additionally, the “Theory and Methods” category reflects that DH requires understanding of accessibility (**INFO 606**) and in sharing and communicating the results of research to various audiences. Approaches to organizing information and making it discoverable (e.g. **INFO 643**), imagining innovative ways of presenting it (**INFO 650**), as well as visualizing it (**INFO 658**, I**NFO 696**) provide pathways for students to disseminate DH research.

Courses that don’t significantly “live” in the digital space, such as INFO 625 Management of Archives & Special Collections and INFO 689 Rare Books and Special Collections, were dropped.

* Changes to existing curriculum are highlighted in yellow.

Existing Curriculum	**Units**	**Revised Curriculum**	**Units**
Required Courses		**Required Courses**	
INFO-657 Digital Humanities	3	INFO-657 Digital Humanities	3
INFO-659 Advanced Projects in Digital Humanities	3	INFO-659 Advanced Projects in Digital Humanities	3
Electives - Select two of the following:		*Electives - Select one from each bucket (2 courses)*	
No Category Here!		***Technologies - Select one***	
INFO-616 Programming Interactive Visualizations	3	INFO-639 Database Design and Development	3
INFO-631 Academic Libraries and Scholarly	3	INFO-638 Web Development	3
INFO-625 Management of Archives and Special Collections	3	INFO-609 Introduction to Spatial Thinking & GIS	3
INFO-670 Linked Open Data for Libraries Archives and Museums	3	INFO-637 Building Web Apps	3
INFO-679 Museums and Digital Culture: Theory and Practice	3	INFO-664 Programming for Cultural Heritage	3

INFO-689 Rare Books & Special Collections	3	INFO-610 Introduction to Statistics	3
Digital Content		INFO-612 Advanced GIS	3
INFO-609 Introduction to Spatial Thinking & GIS	3	INFO-665 Projects in Digital Archives	3
INFO-665 Projects in Digital Archives	3	INFO-616 Programming Interactive Visualizations	3
INFO-647 Visual Resources Management	3	INFO-640 Data Analysis	3
INFO-655 Digital Preservation & Curation	3	INFO-655 Digital Preservation and Curation	3
INFO-658 Information Visualization	3	INFO-658 Information Visualization	3
INFO-640 Data Analysis	3		
INFO-630 Human-Centered Research Design & Methods	3	***Theory and Methods - Select one***	
User Experience (UX)		INFO-630 Human-centered Research Design and Methods	3
INFO-644 Usability Theory & Practice	3	INFO-641 Visual Communication & Information Design	3
INFO-643 Information Architecture & Interaction Design	3	INFO-696 Advanced Projects in Visualization	3
INFO-646 Digital Product Design	3	INFO-643 Information Architecture & Interaction Design	3
INFO-682 Projects in Information Experience Design	3	INFO-650 Speculative Design	3
Special Topics		INFO-679 Museums and Digital Culture: Theory and Practice	3
INFO-611 Information Policies & Politics	3	INFO-606 Digital Accessibility	3
INFO-628 Data Librarianship and Management	3	INFO-622 Storytelling, Design, and Information	3
INFO-663 Metadata Design	3		
INFO-664	3		

Programming For Cultural Heritage			
INFO-681 Community Building & Engagement	3		
Total Credits	12	**Total Credits**	**12**

Appendix

Communications Update

Current	**Revised**
Overview - Grad Catalog The Advanced Certificate in Digital Humanities teaches students how to apply emerging technologies to traditional areas of humanistic inquiry. Since much of this work is situated within academic libraries and cultural heritage institutions, the program emphasizes the special role of information professionals in supporting digital humanities research, teaching, and professional activities.	**Overview - Grad Catalog** The Advanced Certificate in Digital Humanities teaches students how to apply emerging technologies to humanistic inquiry. This certificate provides training in the theories and techniques of Digital Humanities for students who wish to blend Humanistic and computational approaches to exploring difficult questions.
Grad Catalog - Learning Outcomes Not Present.	**Grad Catalog - Learning Outcomes** Add learning outcomes to Grad Catalog.
DH Webpage You'll experience how age-old inquiries into culture, meaning, and value meet emerging technologies and cutting-edge skills. **Overview** The Advanced Certificate in Digital Humanities teaches students how to apply emerging technologies to traditional areas of humanistic inquiry. Since much of this work is situated within academic libraries and cultural heritage institutions, the program emphasizes the special role of information professionals in supporting digital humanities research, teaching, and professional activities.	**DH Webpage** You'll experience how age-old inquiries into culture, meaning, and value meet emerging technologies and cutting-edge skills. **Overview** The Advanced Certificate in Digital Humanities teaches students how to apply emerging technologies to humanistic inquiry. This certificate provides training in the theories and techniques of Digital Humanities for students who wish to blend Humanistic and computational approaches to exploring difficult questions. **What will you do?** Recent job titles obtained by MSLIS graduates with the certificate include:

	Digital Humanities Librarian Digital Scholarship Librarian Instructional Technologist Reference & Instruction Librarian Open Educational Resources, Adjunct Instructor Research Data Librarian **Where will you go?** A selection of institutions and organizations where these graduates work or study: Brown University Columbia University Libraries Cornell University Libraries Fordham University Manhattan College New York City College of Technology New York Institute of Technology Sarah Lawrence College SUNY New Paltz University of Cincinnati Libraries University of Pittsburgh
Academic Requirements	**Academic Requirements** *[Add the following text below the requirements table]* While not required in the certificate, a course in the area of digital preservation is also recommended. Courses that address this area include INFO 655 Digital Preservation and Curation and INFO 665 Projects in Digital Archives. While also not required, students interested in Digital Humanities within the context of academic libraries are also encouraged to take INFO-631 Academic Libraries & Scholarly Communication and INFO-628 Data Librarianship and Management.

Note: Job titles and organizations from earlier website that did not make it over to the new webpage: https://docs.google.com/document/d/1fAWCfxDPjT36mR9RAC7Tgooxa0ngGniRf-ZteQYxKUw/edit?tab=t.0

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